

FOWL, GAMEBIRDS, AND RELATIVES

Strong footed gamebirds are adapted to a wide range of habitats. They are primarily ground-dwellers and feed mostly on plants.

Although they may be good fliers, the majority of gamebirds, the order Galliformes, take to the air only when threatened. None, except the common and Japanese quails, sustains a long migratory flight. Most gamebirds spend their lives on the ground. Only the members of the curassow family of tropical America are habitual tree-dwellers; these birds make their nests in trees, too. Most primitive of the gamebird group are the big-footed megapodes of the Indo-Pacific forests. They bury their eggs in heaps of compost or in volcanic sand and rely on heat generated

by decomposition or volcanic action to incubate them. All other gamebirds take a more active role in parenthood, although only the female raises the brood. The precocious offspring can run and feed soon after hatching.

Male gamebirds often have flamboyant plumage, which they use in courtship displays to attract a harem of females. Some species are armed with leg spurs to battle with competitors.

DOMESTICATED SPECIES

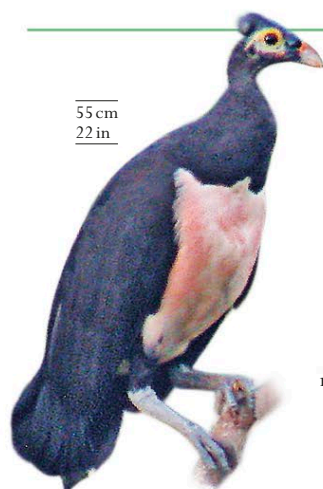
The relative ease with which many gamebird species, including the turkey, can be kept in captivity has meant that they are economically important in many countries. Domesticated chickens around the world are all descendants of the red junglefowl of Southeast Asia.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	GALLIFORMES
FAMILIES	5
SPECIES	300

DEBATE

WHAT IS A PARTRIDGE?

Traditional categories of birds may not reflect biological relationships. Many gamebirds are called partridges, but the European grey partridge differs subtly from others in that, for example, males are more distinctively patterned than females – perhaps making it a closer ally of pheasants.



55 cm
22 in

MALEO

Macrocephalon maleo
F: Megapodiidae

This megapode (large-footed bird) from Sulawesi island in Indonesia lays its eggs in sand and relies on heat from the sun or underground volcanic activity for incubation.



70 cm
28 in

BRUSH TURKEY

Alectura lathami
F: Megapodiidae

Males of this E. Australian megapode control the temperature of their incubation mounds by adding or removing rotting vegetation. More females hatch at high temperatures.

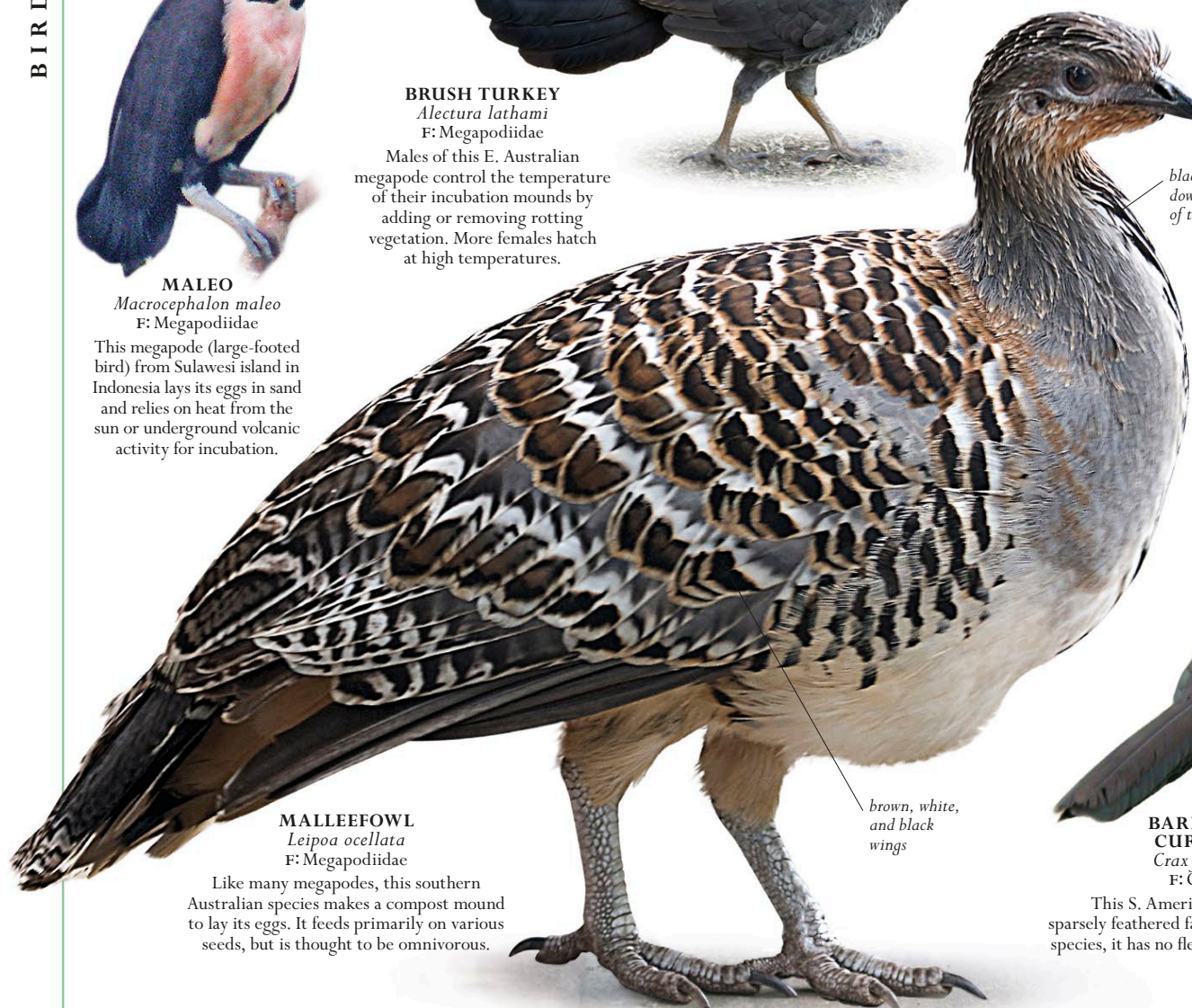


78–92 cm
31–36 in

GREAT CURASSOW

Crax rubra
F: Cracidae

Ranging from Mexico to Ecuador, this large curassow has a curly crest like other curassows. Males are black while females are brown.



MALLEEFOWL

Leipoa ocellata
F: Megapodiidae

Like many megapodes, this southern Australian species makes a compost mound to lay its eggs. It feeds primarily on various seeds, but is thought to be omnivorous.

brown, white,
and black
wings



60 cm
23½ in

84 cm
33 in

BARE-FACED CURASSOW

Crax fasciolata
F: Cracidae

This S. American curassow has a sparsely feathered face. Unlike other related species, it has no fleshy wattles or bill knob.